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INDIA'S NEW BLEND
Since April, E20 has been the standard petrol sold across the country

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

ETHANOL BLENDING

FUEL UNDER FIRE

As India makes E20 petrol the new normal, motorists report falling mileage and engine trouble. Government insists the fuel is safe, tested and vital for energy security

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

BIHAR-BASED YOUTUBER MANISH KASHYAP RECENTLY ALLEGED that his new Toyota Innova Hycross developed engine knocking and vibrations after running on E20 fuel and that the company rejected his warranty claim. Another widely shared post on X came from a car owner who said she was being "forced to destroy" the vehicle she had "fought so hard to get", alleging that E20 fuel had sharply reduced its mileage and impaired its air-conditioning.

Such complaints have multiplied since April, when the Centre made E20 petrol—a blend of 20 per cent ethanol and 80 per cent petrol—the standard fuel sold across India. Ethanol, produced by fermenting crops such as sugarcane, maize and grains, is blended with petrol to reduce dependence on fossil fuels. Yet many car and bike owners, especially those with older, non-E20-compatible vehicles, say the switch has come at a cost. "My car's mileage has dropped from around 18 kmpl to 11-12 kmpl, and sometimes even into single digits," says Gurugram-based Sunil Malhotra, who owns a 2019 Honda City.

This has sparked a debate over whether the nationwide rollout of E20 has outpaced the transition to compatible vehicles. The Centre argues that the ethanol-blended fuel is both scientifically validated and strategically necessary. That case acquired special urgency due to the West Asia crisis, which is still disrupting crude oil supplies. Prime Minister Narendra Modi in late March described ethanol blending as a "saving grace", saying the programme had helped India avoid importing around 45 million barrels of crude oil annually while also saving over Rs 1.5 lakh crore in foreign exchange. Since then, three key ministries—petroleum & natural gas, road transport & highways, and